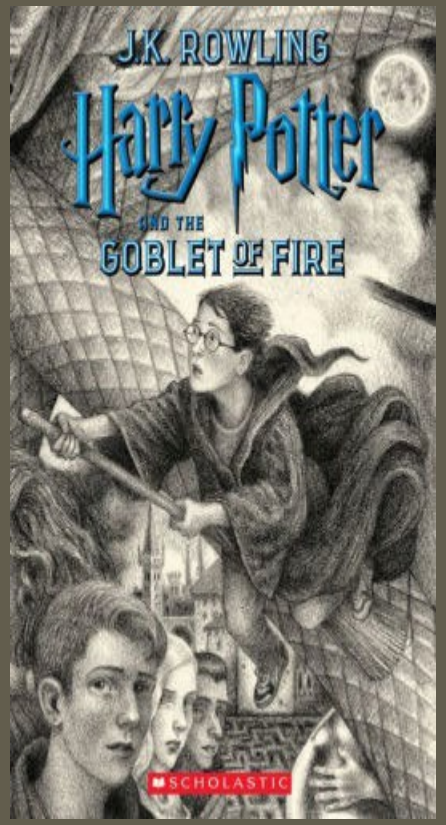
WEEK 7 MGMT2094

How to do Self Reflective Writing

INTRODUCING REFLECTION



Great example from Harry Potter's "The Goblet of Fire" – where Dumbledore (head teacher and Chief Wizard) is talking to Harry about having excess thoughts.

"Harry stared at the stone basin. The contents had returned to their original, silvery white state, swirling and rippling beneath his gaze.

"What is it?" Harry asked shakily.

"This? It is called Pensieve, said Dumbledore. I sometimes find, and I am sure you know the feeling, that I simply have too many thoughts and memories crammed into my mind."

"Err," said Harry., who couldn't truthfully say that he had ever felt anything of the sort.

"At these times" said Dumbledore, indicating the stone basin, "I use the Pensieve. One simply siphons the excess thoughts from one's mind, pours them into a basin, and examines them at one's leisure. It becomes easier to spot patterns and links, you understand when they are in this form." (JK Rowling. 2000)

WHY REFLECT?

- It is not sufficient to merely have experience in order to learn. Without reflecting it may be quickly forgotten or its learning potential lost.
- Moon (1999) suggests reflection is "a form of mental processing with a purpose"



PURPOSES OF REFLECTION

1. Consider the process of our own learning – a process of recognition
2. Critically review something – our own behavior, that of others etc
3. Build on theory from observation
4. Engage in personal or self development
5. Make decisions or resolve uncertainty

In respect to your self reflective writing, it relates to your group experiences, theory on the innovative project you presented and how it may have affected the type and outcome of the project..

REVEAL INFORMATION WISELY:

- A reflective paper is somewhat personal in that it includes your subjective feelings and opinions. Instead of revealing everything about yourself, carefully ask yourself if something is appropriate before including it in your writing
- If you feel uncomfortable about a reflection; don't include it unless it did change the final outcome of your experience. In your writing indicate the concerns you have about such reveals.
- Always maintain a professional and academic tone, whilst yes it is personal and subjective, but it should be keeping your thoughts in an organised fashion and appear sensible.
- Avoid dragging someone else down in your writing. Whilst that person may well have made life difficult for you; you must keep a level of detachment as you describe their influence.

HOW CAN I WRITE A REFLECTIVE PAPER?

- It is one of the few academic papers where you can use "I" in your writing
- You should still relate your subjective feelings and opinions using specific evidence to explain them
- Avoid using slang, jargon etc and always proofread.
- It is NOT a personal journal (diary) entry
- Keep your sentences focused, don't ramble. Avoid squeezing in multiple ideas into one sentence
- Avoid sentence fragments
- Vary your sentence length, but not too long; makes it more conversational
- Use paragraphs

HOW CAN I WRITE A REFLECTIVE PAPER?
CONTD.

- Transitional phrases shift the argument and introduce specific details. They allow you to illustrate how one experience or detail directly links to a conclusion or understanding.
- Common transitional phrases include:
  - For example
  - For instance
  - As a result
  - An opposite view is
  - A different perspective is
- You must relate this to your Group project and experiences, with theoretical underpinnings.

QUESTIONS TO ASK MYSELF?

- What have I learnt from the process?
- What do I now know, that I didn't before?
- What insights have I gained?
- What were the challenges that I encountered/ observed and how well did I and the team handle them?
- What would I do better or differently next time?
- What have I learnt from this?

Remember ultimately do not just describe; you must analyse and reflect!!

Review the criteria within the Group Project and also keep in mind the marking rubric.